

Merck & Co. (MRK): Sac-TMT Further De-Risked by Partner Kelun OptiTROP-Lung06

Overnight, Kelun Biotech, MRK's partner for key pipeline program sac-TMT (see our [sac-TMT Primer](#)), [announced positive topline results for the China Ph3 OptiTROP-Lung06 trial](#) (1L nsq-NSCLC with PD-L1 TPS<1%) meeting the primary endpoint (PFS) at a pre-specified interim analysis — no quantitative details were provided, which we expect at ESMO in October. In a head-to-head comparison with the SOC (Keytruda plus chemo), the sac-TMT/Keytruda combo demonstrated significantly prolonged PFS and a positive OS trend. OptiTROP-Lung06 marks another significant China ph3 success on the heels of OptiTROP-Lung05 in 1L mNSCLC PD-L1 TPS≥1% at [ASCO2026](#), and more importantly provides direct evidence of superiority of sac-TMT/Keytruda combo over the Keytruda/chemo combo (vs. Lung05 trial with Keytruda mono as control).

In our view, these results are particularly significant, as a key question has been MRK's strategy for addressing the 1L mNSCLC PD-L1 TPS<50% population — per MRK's [commentary at our conference](#), positive OptiTROP-Lung06 provides a key de-risking input. On the forward, in terms of next inputs on sac-TMT, we look to ESMO for details, as well as external readouts in the 1L mNSCLC landscape from SMMT's Harmoni-3 and AZN's AVANZAR trial.

Asad Haider, CFA

+1(212)902-0691 | asad.haider@gs.com
Goldman Sachs & Co. LLC

Nick Jennings

+1(415)249-7412 | nick.jennings@gs.com
Goldman Sachs & Co. LLC

Jeff Su

+1(212)357-9930 | jeff.su@gs.com
Goldman Sachs & Co. LLC

Valuation and Risks

Valuation: We arrive at our 12-month target of \$137 using a 14.0x multiple on our (Q5-Q8) adjusted EPS.

Key Downside Risks: Faster-than-expected erosion of the Keytruda LOE / lower than expected conversion to SubQ Keytruda. Further slowdown in established vaccine products, slower ramp of newly launched products, and regulatory uncertainty. Disappointments from pipeline assets. Tougher-than-expected regulatory/market environment related to vaccines, FDA, and tariffs, and M&A.

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MRK	12m Price Target: \$137.00	Price: \$120.78	Upside: 13.4%
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Buy		GS Forecast			
Market cap: \$297.9bn Enterprise value: \$332.6bn 3m ADTV: \$1.2bn United States Americas Pharmaceuticals M&A Rank: 3		12/24	12/25E	12/26E	12/27E
	Revenue (\$ mn)	64,168.0	65,011.0	66,522.6	69,094.6
	EBITDA (\$ mn)	27,239.0	32,618.0	21,947.0	32,807.8
	EBIT (\$ mn)	22,740.0	26,780.0	18,041.0	29,020.7
	EPS (\$)	7.41	8.98	5.14	9.61
	P/E (X)	16.0	13.4	23.5	12.6
	EV/EBITDA (X)	11.9	10.3	15.0	9.7
	FCF yield (%)	6.0	4.1	4.6	7.7
	Dividend yield (%)	2.5	2.5	2.5	2.7
	Net debt/EBITDA (X)	0.9	1.1	1.5	0.7
		9/25	12/25E	3/26E	6/26E
	EPS (\$)	2.58	2.05	(1.28)	2.12

Source: Company data, Goldman Sachs Research estimates, FactSet. Price as of 14 Jul 2026 close.

Disclosure Appendix

Reg AC

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Contributing Authors: Asad Haider, CFA Goldman Sachs & Co. LLC, Nick Jennings Goldman Sachs & Co. LLC, Jeff Su Goldman Sachs & Co. LLC.

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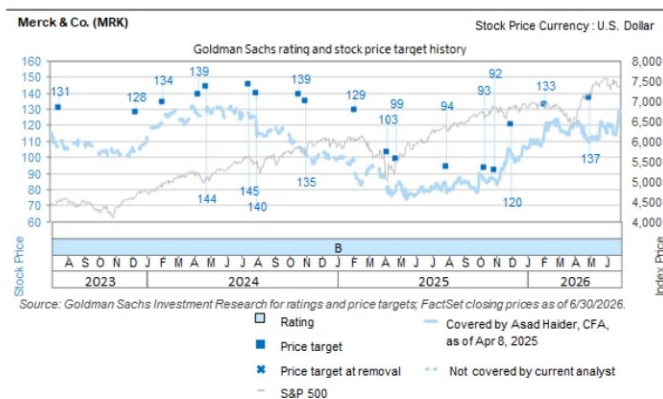
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Merck & Co. (MRK)

Date of report Target price (\$) Closing price (\$)

01-May-26	137.00	112.16
04-Feb-26	133.00	118.33
01-Dec-25	120.00	101.83
31-Oct-25	92.00	85.98
10-Oct-25	93.00	85.99
30-Jul-25	94.00	81.75
25-Apr-25	99.00	82.74
08-Apr-25	103.00	78.95
05-Feb-25	129.00	89.67
01-Nov-24	135.00	101.88
21-Oct-24	139.00	106.34
31-Jul-24	140.00	113.13
16-Jul-24	145.00	125.44
26-Apr-24	144.00	131.20
11-Apr-24	139.00	126.15
02-Feb-24	134.00	126.41
11-Dec-23	128.00	104.37
18-Jul-23	131.00	105.95

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